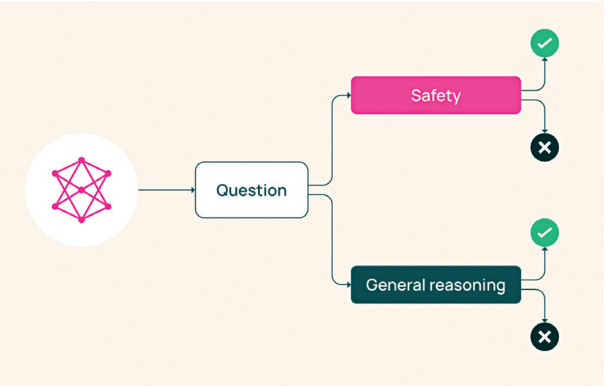


A coding benchmark does not tell you whether the model writes natural Hindi. A maths score does not tell you whether it summarises your PDFs faithfully. Prompt format, tools, model revision and inference settings can also affect scores.

Use benchmarks to ask whether a model appears competitive for your task, whether it has obvious weak spots and whether results have been independently reproduced. Then test shortlisted models with your own prompts.

Step 5: Check the licence now

Hugging Face can display licence information directly in model metadata, and licences can be used as a search filter. Authors may choose common licences or specify custom terms and link to their own text.

Click it.

For private experimentation, restrictions may not affect you immediately. But if you later share the model, build a commercial service, redistribute a fine-tune or use it inside a business, the licence matters.

Do not infer permissions from "open", "community" or "free download". Read the terms. Also distinguish the original model's licence from whatever a derivative repository claims. A fine-tuner cannot erase upstream obligations.

Add licence to your shortlist just as you add RAM requirements.

Step 6: Understand Files and versions

Now open Files.

Depending on the repository, you might see:

- `safetensors`
- `.gguf`
- `.bin`
- `config.json`
- `tokenizer.json`
- vocabulary files
- generation configuration
- chat templates
- README and licence files
- multiple weight shards

Do not download everything automatically.

A Transformers-style repository may split weights across several Safetensors shards accompanied by an index. A local llama.cpp-oriented GGUF repository may instead contain multiple quantisations of the same model.

This is where Chapter 2 pays off. If you want Q4_K_M, select that exact GGUF rather than Q8_0 because its name looks more impressive. If your runtime expects a full Transformers repository, one weight shard by itself will not be enough.

Also notice revision history. Hugging Face downloads can target the latest main revision, a branch, tag or an exact commit hash. A repository can change after you first download it, so recording the model ID and revision is useful when you want to reproduce a setup later.

Step 7: Pick the right GGUF without filling your SSD

A GGUF repository may offer the same model in Q2, Q3, Q4, Q5, Q6, Q8 and other variants.

You know the trade-off: lower-bit quantisation reduces storage and memory requirements, usually at some quality cost.

Use this sequence:

First, estimate available memory. Leave headroom for the operating system, runtime and context.

Second, find the largest sensible quantisation that fits comfortably rather than barely.

Third, if uncertain, begin around a mainstream four- or five-bit quantisation where available.

Fourth, note the file size before downloading.

Fifth, try another quantisation only for a reason: the first is too large, too slow, or you want to test whether higher precision materially improves your workload.

Do not collect every version. Three 10GB experiments have a habit of becoming 100GB of "I'll delete those later".

GGUF can package model tensors and metadata while supporting the quantised representations commonly used for local inference. Choose the file your hardware and runtime need, not every file the repository offers.

Step 8: Know what "gated" means

Sometimes model files are not immediately available.

Hugging Face allows authors to make repositories gated. To access one, you must log in and request access through the browser. You agree to share your Hugging Face username and email address with the model author, and some models request additional information. Approval may be automatic or manually reviewed.

Gated does not necessarily mean paid or private. Authors may use gating to require acceptance of licence terms or control access to research releases.